

layers semi-transparent and easily visualise your board's stack up. The feature brings you the feel of a three-dimensional cuboid. Gerbv also supports complex layer operations like knockout. You can also perform functions such as and, or, xor and invert.

Juggle a number of files. If you are working with multiple Gerber files, you can superimpose these, placing one on top of the other. As a general practice, upper layer is the top metal layer. This approach prominently helps you compare two supposedly identical layouts to spot differences easily, or to see how it might look if the different designs are combined together, although routing will certainly be different then.

Compare and contrast

You might have to create an upgraded version of a previously-manufactured PCB. It is natural to want to compare your new board with the original, or your reference board, to get the measurements right and the components in perfect place. This is exactly where Gerbv comes in.

The program lets you open several circuit designs at the same time, with windows showing up on top of one another. Comparison is easy and so is measurement. You can choose to have the scale show up in centimetres, millimetres or inches.

Maneuvering through the various tabs on the screen is easy, with a simple interface that leaves all controls at the top. The layers you are sifting through can be accessed via the tabs on left side of the window.

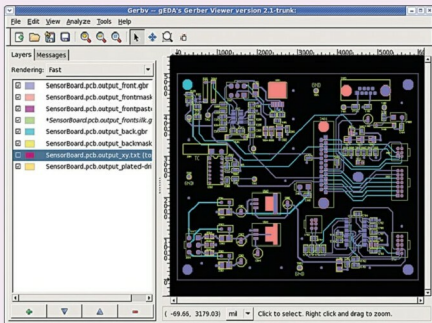


Fig. 2: Tracing your connections using Gerbv

All about the core library

Core of the software is contained in a library called libgerbv. This is available as a separate library in order to allow other software to easily incorporate advanced Gerber functionality. This allows you to incorporate Gerber parsing, editing, exporting or rendering into other programs.

Compatibility comes as a boon to you if you have to shift between tools. Core also comes with code documentation that is built to help new users fast track their understanding of Gerbv. Documentation, which can be found at <http://gerbv.geda-project.org/doxygen/index.html>, details the libgerbv application programming interface with examples, source codes and makefiles to help you make a quick start.

Go the developer way or choose the GUI

While you could choose to go with command mode interface, the software comes with a simple, no-fuss graphical user interface (GUI). Built on a regular window base with a plain and simple structure, it offers the perfect viewing scenario for Gerber files. The background also proves a worthy aid to drill, pick and place due to clarity and ease of identification.

Viewing layer properties, selecting or deleting objects, modifying layer orientation, zooming in and out, making measurements and customising background colour, all these happen with a click of the mouse. Gerbv supports auto-scaling to make your design fit the size of your screen. There are also a couple of



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